

THE BOATMAN AND THE SCHOLAR

Characters:

1. Narrator
2. Scholar
3. Boatman
4. Passenger

SCENE 1 — THE JOURNEY

[Boatman is rowing. Scholar and Passenger are sitting in the boat.]

Narrator:

One day, a proud scholar was travelling across a river by boat. He was highly educated and very proud of his knowledge.

Passenger:

What a beautiful day! The river is so calm and peaceful.

Boatman:

Yes, sir. Don't worry. The weather is perfect for travelling.

Scholar:

Hmm... You seem very confident, boatman.

Boatman:

I have been travelling on this river for many years, sir.

Passenger:

Then you must know this river very well.

Boatman:

Yes, sir. I know almost every part of it.

Scholar:

Know the river? That's not enough.

Passenger:

Why, sir?

Scholar:

A person should have proper education. Books give us real knowledge.

Boatman:

Maybe you are right, sir.

Scholar:

Tell me, boatman. Have you studied History?

Boatman:

No, sir.

Scholar:

Oh! Then half of your life is wasted!

Passenger:

Half of his life?!

Scholar:

Of course! History teaches us about the past.

Passenger:

But he is a boatman, sir. He spends his life on the river.

Scholar:

That is exactly the problem. He should have studied!

SCENE 2 — THE QUESTIONS

Scholar:

Tell me, boatman. Do you know Geography?

Boatman:

No, sir.

Scholar:

Another part of your life is wasted!

Passenger:

Sir, you are wasting more of his life by asking questions!

Scholar:

Very funny. Do you know Science?

Boatman:

No, sir.

Scholar:

Mathematics?

Boatman:

No, sir.

Scholar:

Literature?

Boatman:

No, sir.

Scholar:

My goodness! What do you know?

Boatman:

I know how to row a boat.

Scholar:

Rowing a boat? Is that knowledge?

Passenger:

Well, without that knowledge, we'd still be standing at the shore.

Boatman:

Exactly, sir.

Scholar:

Nonsense! Book knowledge is far more important.

Passenger:

Perhaps both kinds of knowledge are important.

Scholar:

You too?

Passenger:

I am just saying, sir.

Scholar:

Let me ask you something, then. What do you know?

Passenger:

Me?

Scholar:

Yes.

Passenger:

I know that I paid for this journey, so I would like to reach the other side alive.

[Passenger looks at Boatman.]

Boatman:

Don't worry, sir. I'll get you there safely.

Passenger:

Thank you. At least one person here is concerned about our journey!

SCENE 3 — THE STORM

Narrator:

The boatman continued rowing. But after some time, the peaceful weather suddenly changed.

Dark clouds covered the sky, and a strong wind began to blow.

Passenger:

Wait... Is that a storm?

Boatman:

Yes. Everyone, stay calm!

Scholar:

A storm?!

Passenger:

The waves are getting bigger!

Boatman:

Hold on tightly!

[Everyone acts as if the boat is shaking.]

Passenger:

Boatman! The boat is moving too much!

Boatman:

Don't panic! I'm trying to control it!

Scholar:

What should we do?!

Boatman:

The boat is filling with water!

Passenger:

Oh no! We're going to sink!

Scholar:

My books! My books are getting wet!

Passenger:

Forget your books!

Boatman:

Exactly! Save yourself first!

Scholar:

But my books are very valuable!

Passenger:

Sir, right now your life is more valuable than your books!

Boatman:

Everyone, be ready. We may have to jump into the river.

Passenger:

Jump?!

Scholar:

Into that water?!

Boatman:

Yes!

SCENE 4 — THE REVERSAL

Scholar:

Boatman! Tell us what to do!

Boatman:

If the boat sinks, we have to swim to the shore.

Passenger:

I can swim!

Boatman:

Good.

[Looks at Scholar.]

Boatman:

What about you, sir?

Scholar:

I... I...

Passenger:

Wait! Don't tell me.

[Looks at Scholar dramatically.]

Passenger:

After all those questions...

Boatman:

Sir, you asked me about History.

Scholar:

Yes...

Boatman:

You asked me about Geography.

Scholar:

Yes...

Boatman:

Science, Mathematics and Literature.

Scholar:

Yes...

Boatman:

But now I have one question for you.

Scholar:

What question?

[Boatman pauses.]

Boatman:

Do you know how to swim?

[2-second pause.]

Scholar:

No...

[Boatman looks at Passenger.]

Passenger:

Oh, dear...

Boatman:

Then your whole life is wasted!

SCENE 5 — THE LESSON

Narrator:

That day, the scholar learned an important lesson.

Knowledge is valuable, but knowledge becomes truly useful when we can apply it in real life.

ALL:

“Bookish knowledge is valuable, but practical knowledge can save a life!”